

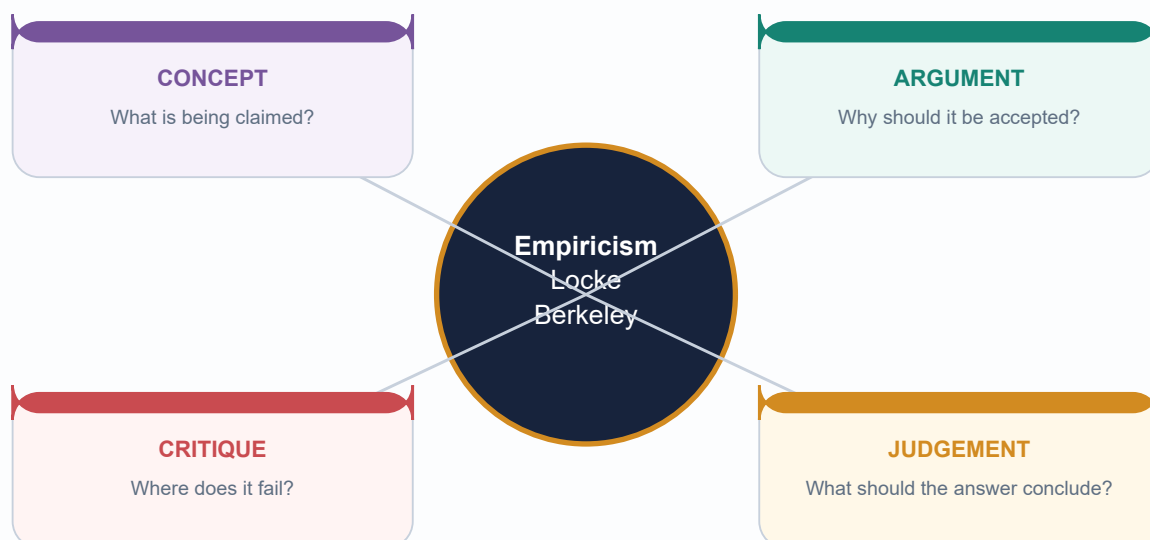
UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

Empiricism — Locke, Berkeley and Hume — Complete Visual Notes

UPSC Philosophy Optional • Paper I • Western Philosophy

Syllabus: Theory of Knowledge; Substance and Qualities; Self and God; Scepticism.

Direct local-book analysis • Verified knowledge cross-check • PYQ-mapped answer writing



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Master Map, Context and Technical Vocabulary

Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

British empiricism begins with experience as the source of ideas, progressively criticises material substance and ends in Hume's scepticism about self, causation and necessary connection.

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 146–212 (Locke and Hume); Think, PDF pp. 544–582 (Berkeley); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 116–119 (Berkeley).

TIMELINE

1690 — Locke's Essay rejects innate principles

1710 — Berkeley's Principles attacks material substance

1739–40 — Hume's Treatise radicalises the theory of ideas

1748 — Hume's Enquiry refines the critique of causation

WHOLE-TOPIC DOCTRINE MAP

EMPIRICISM — LOCKE, BERKELEY AND HUME

Locke Ideas from sensation and reflection; qualities; substratum	Berkeley Esse est percipi; ideas and spirits; nominalism
Hume Impressions, ideas, bundle self, custom and scepticism	Internal logic Experience-only standard erodes substance and necessity

KEY DATA

Term	Precise Meaning	Answer Use
Tabula rasa	No innate speculative content	Frame Locke's starting point
Primary quality	Purportedly object-inherent feature	Explain Berkeley's criticism
Esse est percipi	To be sensible is to be perceived	State Berkeley without solipsism
Impression / idea	Lively perception / faint copy	Use Hume's copy principle
Custom	Habit producing causal expectation	Answer causation questions

STATIC THEORY

- **Syllabus coverage:** Theory of Knowledge; Substance and Qualities; Self and God; Scepticism.
- **Intellectual context:** British empiricism begins with experience as the source of ideas, progressively criticises material substance and ends in Hume's scepticism about self, causation and necessary connection.
- **Source discipline:** claims were reconciled with the verified topic note, recent PYQs and the directly read local books listed below.
- **Theme cross-check:** substance, a priori knowledge and critiques of metaphysics were checked where relevant.

MEMORY HOOK

L-B-H: Locke limits knowledge, Berkeley removes matter, Hume dissolves substance and necessity.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Define each technical term before evaluating it.
2. Reconstruct the internal argument, not merely the conclusion.
3. Distinguish the thinker's own doctrine from a later label or criticism.
4. Use comparisons only after identifying the shared philosophical problem.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Locke says the mind has no capacities before experience.

CORRECT: He denies innate ideas, not native cognitive powers.

WRONG: Berkeley denies all reality.

CORRECT: He denies mind-independent matter while affirming ideas and spirits.

WRONG: Hume proves events are uncaused.

CORRECT: He denies perception or rational proof of necessary connection.

CROSS-SYLLABUS CONCEPT LINKS

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Primary qualities	Scientific realism	Test whether object–idea resemblance can be sustained
Substance	Rationalism and Strawson	Trace erosion and later conceptual revival
Causation	Kant	Hume's challenge triggers the synthetic a priori response
Bundle self	Buddhist no-self	A careful cross-tradition comparison

MAINS ANGLE

Open with the problem that generates the doctrine; end by judging its explanatory gain against its strongest internal cost.

STUDY LINK

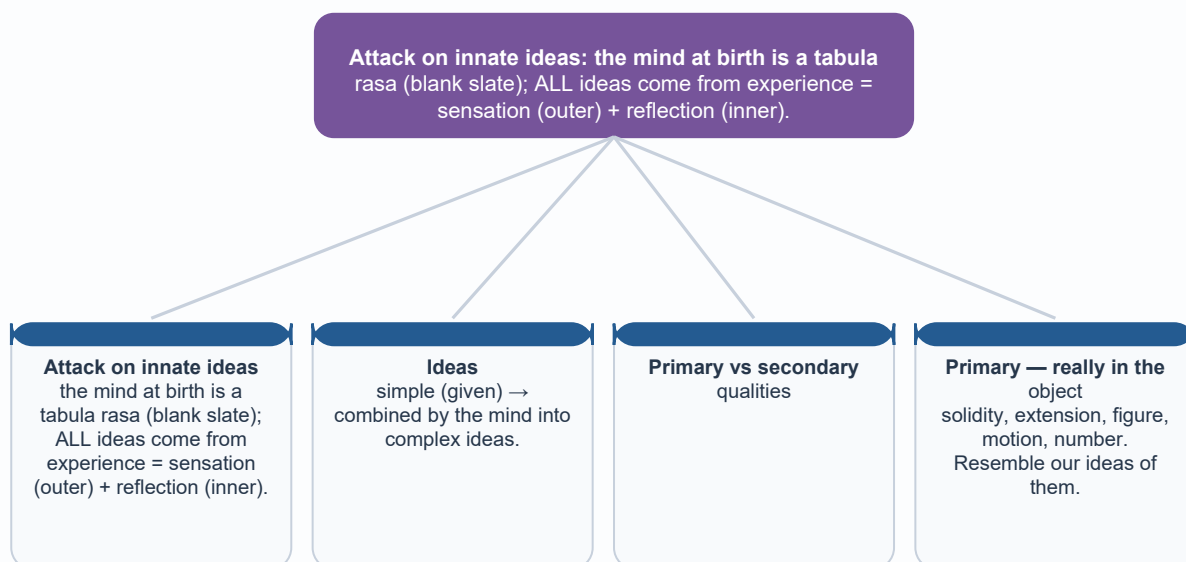
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HIGH**1. LOCKE — the empiricist foundation — Part 1**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Attack on innate ideas: the mind at birth is a tabula rasa (blank slate); ALL ideas come from experience = sensation (outer) + reflection (inner).

*Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 146–212 (Locke and Hume); Think, PDF pp. 544–582 (Berkeley); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 116–119 (Berkeley).*

1. LOCKE — THE EMPIRICIST FOUNDATION — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE



STATIC THEORY

- Attack on innate ideas: the mind at birth is a tabula rasa (blank slate); ALL ideas come from experience = sensation (outer) + reflection (inner).
- Ideas: simple (given) → combined by the mind into complex ideas.
- Primary vs secondary qualities:
- Primary — really in the object: solidity, extension, figure, motion, number. Resemble our ideas of them.
- Secondary — powers in the object to produce sensations in us: colour, sound, taste, smell, heat. Do NOT resemble anything in the object.
- Substance: since we only ever perceive qualities, the underlying substratum is unknown — a "something-I-know-not-what" (a supposed but unknowable support of qualities).
- Representative realism: we perceive ideas, which represent external things (the "veil of ideas"). → opens the sceptical gap Berkeley & Hume exploit.

MEMORY HOOK

CLAIM → REASON → CONSEQUENCE → OBJECTION → QUALIFIED REPLY.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Attack on innate ideas: the mind at birth is a tabula rasa (blank slate); ALL ideas come from experience = sensation (outer) + reflection (inner).
2. Ideas: simple (given) → combined by the mind into complex ideas.
3. Primary vs secondary qualities:
4. Primary — really in the object: solidity, extension, figure, motion, number. Resemble our ideas of them.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Locke says the mind has no capacities before experience.

CORRECT: He denies innate ideas, not native cognitive powers.

WRONG: Berkeley denies all reality.

CORRECT: He denies mind-independent matter while affirming ideas and spirits.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 146–212 (Locke and Hume); Think, PDF pp. 544–582 (Berkeley); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 116–119 (Berkeley).

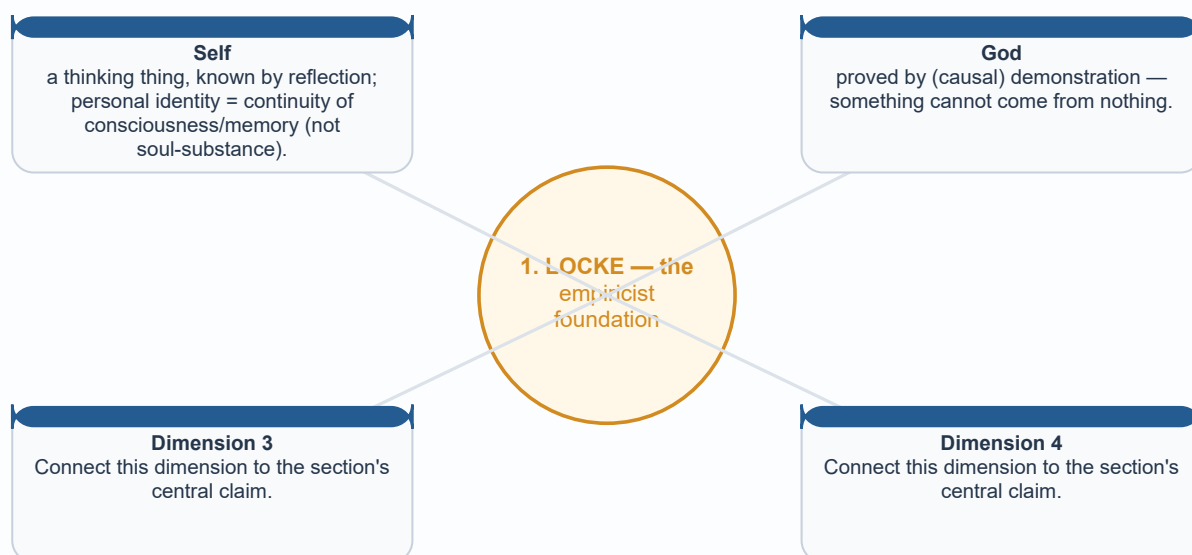
HIGH**1. LOCKE — the empiricist foundation — Part 2**

Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Self: a thinking thing, known by reflection; personal identity = continuity of consciousness/memory (not soul-substance).

Continuation: preserve the full semantic chain before moving to criticism.

1. LOCKE — THE EMPIRICIST FOUNDATION — CONCEPTUAL LANDSCAPE**STATIC THEORY**

- Self: a thinking thing, known by reflection; personal identity = continuity of consciousness/memory (not soul-substance).
- God: proved by (causal) demonstration — something cannot come from nothing.

MEMORY HOOK

L-B-H: Locke limits knowledge, Berkeley removes matter, Hume dissolves substance and necessity.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Self: a thinking thing, known by reflection; personal identity = continuity of consciousness/memory (not soul-substance).
2. God: proved by (causal) demonstration — something cannot come from nothing.

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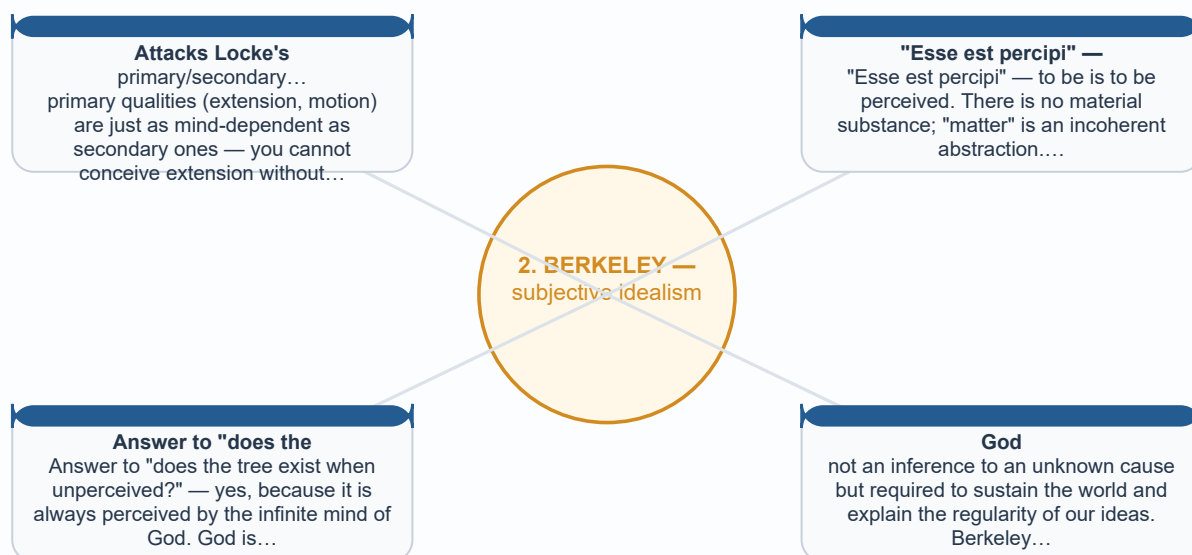
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HIGH**2. BERKELEY — subjective idealism**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Attacks Locke's primary/secondary distinction: primary qualities (extension, motion) are just as mind-dependent as secondary ones — you cannot conceive extension without some colour/sensation. So ALL qualities are ideas.

Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 146–212 (Locke and Hume); *Think*, PDF pp. 544–582 (Berkeley); *Cambridge Dictionary*, PDF pp. 116–119 (Berkeley).

2. BERKELEY — SUBJECTIVE IDEALISM — CONCEPTUAL LANDSCAPE

STATIC THEORY

- Attacks Locke's primary/secondary distinction: primary qualities (extension, motion) are just as mind-dependent as secondary ones — you cannot conceive extension without some colour/sensation. So ALL qualities are ideas.
- "Esse est percipi" — to be is to be perceived. There is no material substance; "matter" is an incoherent abstraction. Reality = minds (spirits) + their ideas.
- Answer to "does the tree exist when unperceived?" — yes, because it is always perceived by the infinite mind of God. God is the cause of the orderly, involuntary ideas we call the "real world."
- God: not an inference to an unknown cause but required to sustain the world and explain the regularity of our ideas. Berkeley uses empiricism to defend theism (against materialist atheism).
- Self/spirit: the perceiving mind is a real active substance (Berkeley keeps the self — Hume won't).

MEMORY HOOK

L-B-H: Locke limits knowledge, Berkeley removes matter, Hume dissolves substance and necessity.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Attacks Locke's primary/secondary distinction: primary qualities (extension, motion) are just as mind-dependent as secondary ones — you cannot conceive extension without some colour/sensation. So ALL qualities are ideas.
2. "Esse est percipi" — to be is to be perceived. There is no material substance; "matter" is an incoherent abstraction. Reality = minds (spirits) + their ideas.
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HIGH

3. HUME — empiricism becomes scepticism

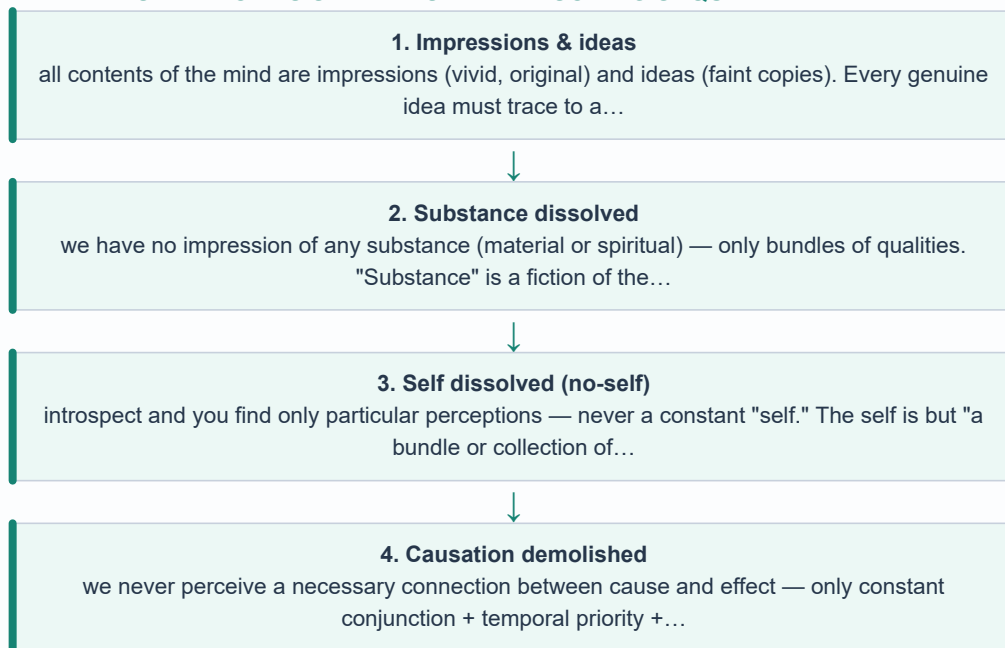
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Impressions & ideas: all contents of the mind are impressions (vivid, original) and ideas (faint copies). Every genuine idea must trace to a prior impression — Hume's "microscope." If no impression, the idea is empty.

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 146–212 (Locke and Hume); Think, PDF pp. 544–582 (Berkeley); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 116–119 (Berkeley).

3. HUME — EMPIRICISM BECOMES SCEPTICISM — REASONING SEQUENCE



STATIC THEORY

- Impressions & ideas: all contents of the mind are impressions (vivid, original) and ideas (faint copies). Every genuine idea must trace to a prior impression — Hume's "microscope." If no impression, the idea is empty.
- Substance dissolved: we have no impression of any substance (material or spiritual) — only bundles of qualities. "Substance" is a fiction of the imagination.
- Self dissolved (no-self): introspect and you find only particular perceptions — never a constant "self." The self is but "a bundle or collection of different perceptions" in perpetual flux. (striking parallel with Buddhist *nairātmya* — a great cross-paper/cross-tradition bridge.)
- Causation demolished: we never perceive a necessary connection between cause and effect — only constant conjunction + temporal priority + contiguity. Our idea of "necessary connection" is merely a habit/custom of the mind expecting the usual sequence.
- Induction problem: past regularities give no rational guarantee of the future; induction rests on custom, not reason.
- God: the causal & design arguments fail (no impression of the cause of the universe; Hume's Dialogues dismantle the design argument — directly relevant to Paper-II).
- Result — mitigated scepticism: reason cannot justify belief in matter, self, causation, or God; yet nature/custom compels us to believe and live.

MEMORY HOOK

L-B-H: Locke limits knowledge, Berkeley removes matter, Hume dissolves substance and necessity.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Impressions & ideas: all contents of the mind are impressions (vivid, original) and ideas (faint copies). Every genuine idea must trace to a prior impression — Hume's "microscope." If no impression, the idea is empty.
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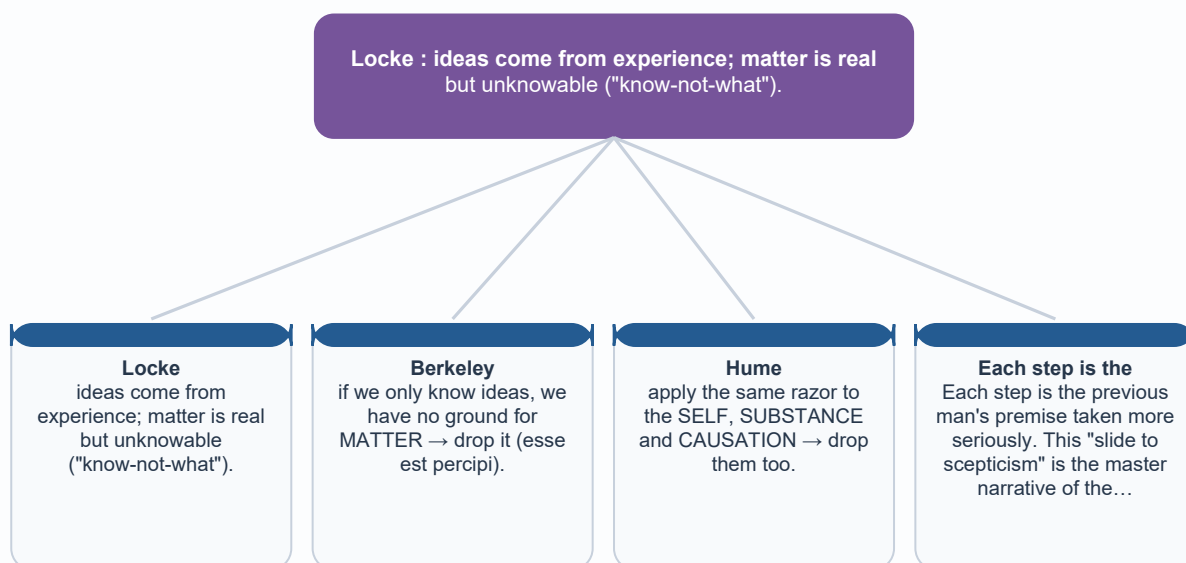
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HIGH**4. THE INTERNAL LOGIC — why empiricism slides**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Locke : ideas come from experience; matter is real but unknowable ("know-not-what").

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 146–212 (Locke and Hume); Think, PDF pp. 544–582 (Berkeley); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 116–119 (Berkeley).

4. THE INTERNAL LOGIC — WHY EMPIRICISM SLIDES — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE

STATIC THEORY

- Locke : ideas come from experience; matter is real but unknowable ("know-not-what").
- Berkeley : if we only know ideas, we have no ground for MATTER → drop it (esse est percipi).
- Hume : apply the same razor to the SELF, SUBSTANCE and CAUSATION → drop them too.
- Each step is the previous man's premise taken more seriously. This "slide to scepticism" is the master narrative of the whole item — and what provokes Kant (item 4) to rescue knowledge.

MEMORY HOOK

L-B-H: Locke limits knowledge, Berkeley removes matter, Hume dissolves substance and necessity.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Locke : ideas come from experience; matter is real but unknowable ("know-not-what").
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HIGH

Criticisms, Replies, Comparisons and Verified Statement Bank

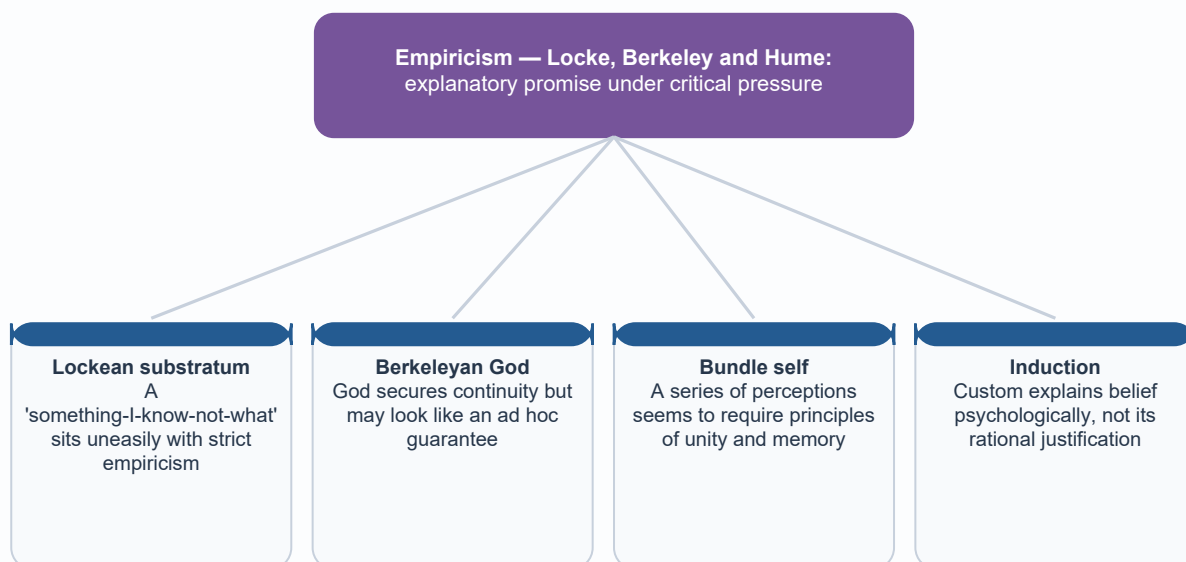
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

A high-scoring critical answer distinguishes an external rejection from an immanent objection and gives the strongest available reply before judging the doctrine.

Statement bank retained only where the verified local topic file marks the wording as canonical; all other formulations are treated as paraphrase.

CLAIM–OBJECTION–REPLY ARCHITECTURE



KEY DATA

Axis	Locke	Berkeley	Hume
Matter	real but unknowable	does not exist	no impression → fiction
Qualities	primary vs secondary	all mind-dependent	all impressions
Self	consciousness-continuity	active spirit (real)	bundle (no self)
Causation	real power	God's will	constant conjunction + habit
God	causal proof	sustainer of ideas	proofs fail (sceptic)
Upshot	representative realism	idealism	scepticism

STATIC THEORY

- **Critical pressure:** Lockean substratum — A 'something-I-know-not-what' sits uneasily with strict empiricism
- **Critical pressure:** Berkeleyan God — God secures continuity but may look like an ad hoc guarantee
- **Critical pressure:** Bundle self — A series of perceptions seems to require principles of unity and memory
- **Critical pressure:** Induction — Custom explains belief psychologically, not its rational justification

MEMORY HOOK

C-O-R-J: CLAIM → strongest OBJECTION → plausible REPLY → reasoned JUDGEMENT.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Locke: the mind is "white paper, void of all characters" (tabula rasa); substance = "a something, I know not what."
2. Berkeley: "Esse est percipi" — to be is to be perceived.
3. Hume: the self is "a bundle or collection of different perceptions, which succeed each other with an inconceivable rapidity."
4. Hume: causation is "the constant conjunction" of objects + a "habit" of the mind, not a perceived necessary connection.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Criticism means listing hostile names.

CORRECT: State the objection's premise, target and consequence.

WRONG: A quotation can replace exposition.

CORRECT: Unpack the statement's technical meaning and argumentative role.

WRONG: Comparison is two separate summaries.

CORRECT: Compare axis-by-axis around a shared problem.

COMPARATIVE ROUTES

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Primary qualities	Scientific realism	Test whether object–idea resemblance can be sustained
Substance	Rationalism and Strawson	Trace erosion and later conceptual revival
Causation	Kant	Hume's challenge triggers the synthetic a priori response
Bundle self	Buddhist no-self	A careful cross-tradition comparison

MAINS ANGLE

Use the statement as a compressed argument: define its terms, reconstruct what follows, stage the strongest objection and give a qualified verdict.

STUDY LINK

Verified knowledge file: Empiricism.md •
 Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 146–212 (Locke and Hume); Think, PDF pp. 544–582 (Berkeley); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 116–119 (Berkeley).

HIGH**PYQs, Applied Drills and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Architecture**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The final layer converts doctrine into directive-sensitive answers. Keep exposition proportionate to marks, reserve space for criticism and end with a qualified philosophical judgement.

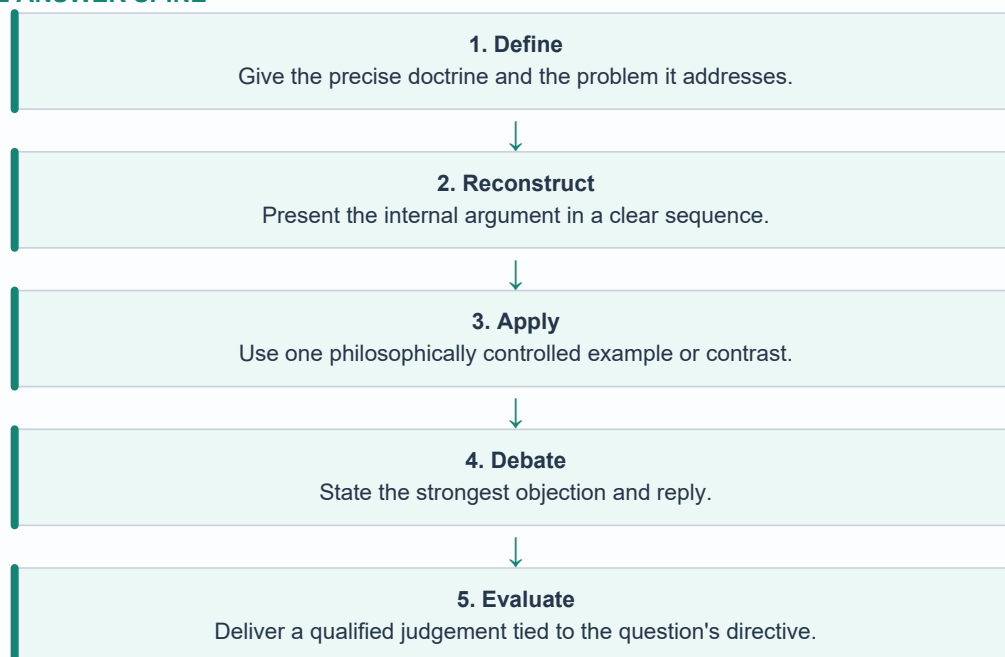
PYQs reproduced from the local UPSC Western Philosophy bank for 2022–2025; wording is shortened only in the table, not altered in doctrinal demand.

RECENT DIRECT PYQ YIELD



KEY DATA

Year	Verified Demand	Marks
2025	Berkeley's nominalism and critique of abstract ideas	15
2025	Hume on causation and Kant's response	15
2024	Berkeley against primary qualities and comparison with Hegel	20
2023	Hume: causality as custom and association	20
2023	Locke against Descartes' innate ideas	15
2022	Locke: source and limits of knowledge	15

D-R-A-D-E ANSWER SPINE**STATIC THEORY**

- **10 marks:** 2-line context; define the key term; 3–4 linked doctrinal points; one precise objection; 2-line judgement.
- **15 marks:** establish the problem; reconstruct the argument with technical vocabulary; add comparison or example; objection–reply; balanced conclusion.
- **20 marks:** map every syllabus dimension in the question; develop the derivation; compare alternatives; stage two critical pressures; defend or qualify; conclude with an explicit criterion of success.
- [Slide] "Empiricism logically culminates in scepticism. Discuss (Locke→Berkeley→Hume)."
- [Substance] "Compare Locke's, Berkeley's and Hume's views on substance."
- [Causation] "Examine Hume's analysis of causation and its sceptical consequences."
- [Self] "Hume's bundle-theory of the self — examine (and compare Buddhist *nairātmya*)."
- [Compare traditions] "Rationalism vs Empiricism on the source of knowledge." (→ sets up Kant)
- **8.1 — "Empiricism culminates in scepticism. Discuss." (recurring)**
 - Frame : shared premise — all ideas from experience.
 - Body : Locke (matter real-but-unknown) → Berkeley (drops matter) → Hume (drops self, substance, causation).
 - Engine: each applies the empiricist razor more consistently.
 - Assess: Hume's scepticism is the premise's honest end-point → provokes Kant's rescue.
 - Concl : empiricism, taken strictly, undermines the very knowledge it began by grounding.
- **8.2 — "Examine Hume's theory of causation." (item 3, high-frequency)**
 - Intro : we seek a necessary connection; Hume says we never perceive one.

MEMORY HOOK

MARKS CONTROL DEPTH: 10 = compact argument; 15 = argument + debate; 20 = complete architecture + sustained evaluation.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The directive determines emphasis: explain, examine, compare and evaluate are not interchangeable.
2. A 20-mark answer must show relations among subparts, not merely add more bullet points.
3. Use one stable example through exposition and criticism where possible.
4. Conclusions should identify what the doctrine successfully explains and what remains unresolved.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Memorise one essay for every wording.

CORRECT: Adapt the same doctrine map to the directive and marks.

WRONG: Criticism should occupy most of the answer.

CORRECT: Secure accurate exposition before proportionate evaluation.

WRONG: A conclusion merely repeats the introduction.

CORRECT: It must state a defended philosophical judgement.

MAINS ANGLE

For statement questions, treat the quotation as a claim needing reconstruction; for comparison, organise by axes; for 'does it solve' questions, state an explicit success criterion.

STUDY LINK

Official local PYQ bank:

[_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2022-2025.md](#)

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI